Twin Lanterns, Volume 1: The North Tower

The first volume of the Twin Lanterns cycle

The Example Maintainers

Example Editions

2026

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Dedication

For the two keepers of the twin lights, who never once agreed on the weather and never once missed a night.

The Two Lights

Two towers stand at the mouth of the same bay, one on each headland, close enough to signal and too far to shout. The keepers of the north tower and the south tower have corresponded by lantern code for eleven years, and the code has grown to four hundred signals, of which three hundred and ninety are about the weather.

The cycle this volume begins follows both towers through one year of weather that neither keeper predicted and both recorded anyway.

Chapter 1

The North Road

The road to the north tower climbs for two hours and argues with the wind for both of them. The new keeper walked it in March with a suitcase, a barometer and a letter of appointment signed by someone who had never seen the sea.

At the top of the road the tower appeared exactly as the letter had not described it: taller, colder, and already lit.

1.1 The Register

Inside the door stood the register, the nightly log of the station. The last entry was four days old and read only: fog, thick, singing. The new keeper read it three times and decided the singing could wait until she had unpacked the barometer.

1.2 First Signal

At dusk the south tower lit its lamp twice, paused, and lit it twice again. The code book said this meant is the road still open. The new keeper opened her lantern shutter once and hoped it meant yes.

Chapter 2

The Tower

The tower had one hundred and nine steps, a lamp room, a kitchen, and opinions. The stairs creaked in a sequence the keepers learned as a tune; the kitchen window stuck in April and unstuck itself in October without assistance.

The lamp itself was well behaved. It wanted oil, a clean chimney and one honest hour of maintenance a day, and in exchange it drew its beam across the water without once asking what the weather intended.

2.1 The Singing Fog

The fog arrived on the fourth night and kept the register's promise. It did not howl and it did not whisper; it sang, low and steady, like a choir that had forgotten the words but remembered the key. The new keeper wrote: fog, thick, singing, confirmed.

Chapter 3

The Keeper

By summer the new keeper had a routine, a code-book margin full of corrections, and a correspondent she had never met. The lantern code had grown by two signals: one for the barometer is lying, and one for come and see this, which they used more than either expected.

On the last night of the volume, both towers burned steady through a storm that arrived early and left late, and in the morning the register of the north tower read, for the first time in eleven years: weather unchanged, correspondence continuing.

Appendix A

Glossary

Lantern code - the four hundred signals the two towers exchange by shutter and lamp. Three hundred and ninety concern the weather; the remainder concern everything else.

Register - the nightly log of a station. Weather first, confirmation second, correspondence third.

Singing fog - fog that arrives with a key and no words. Recorded, confirmed, and never explained.